

iSecretCall for Expressions of Interest	
<i>Date of Issue:</i>	September 2026
<i>Expected Completion Date:</i>	May 2027
<i>Project Title:</i>	Analysing the Archives: Interrogating the Gongster Student Newspapers
<i>Company:</i>	Manuscripts and Special Collections, University of Nottingham
Contact Details	
<i>Lead Contact:</i>	Sarah Colborne
<i>Lead E-mail:</i>	Sarah.colborne@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Charlotte May
<i>E-mail:</i>	Charlotte.may@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Laura Peaurt
<i>E-mail:</i>	Laura.peaurt@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Additional contact name
<i>E-mail:</i>	Additional contact e-mail
Additional Info	
<i>Students must sign NDA:</i>	☒
<i>Project uses personal data:</i>	☒
<i>Custom hardware required:</i>	☐ If Applicable: Please provide details
<i>Relevant research areas (if applicable)¹:</i>	Digital humanities, text and image recognition, trend analysis
Project Background Information	
Gongster was a University of Nottingham newspaper written, edited and produced by students. Manuscripts and Special Collections (MSC) hold an almost complete set from its inception in 1939 to its current magazine equivalent, Impact, still being published today. MSC have created high resolution scans of the issues from 1939 through to 1991 and have run OCR software over the images to create a text searchable set of PDFs, with issues packaged together by academic year. The PDFs are currently only accessible in the Manuscripts reading room on a PC which is not connected to the network, as the newspapers can contain discriminatory language, descriptions of offensive behaviour and potentially libellous commentary on individuals who may still be alive and who may be public figures. There is also a duty of care to the students who wrote the articles at the time who may now be embarrassed by opinions they used to hold.	

¹ An overview of different research areas in the school of computer science can be found [here](#).

An example of one of the issues which illustrates many of these concerns can be found online here, hosted by an anarchist library [content warning – contains nudity]:

https://www.thesparrowsnest.org.uk/collections/public_archive/8676.pdf

Currently the collection of scans is generally interrogated using the free text search available in the PDF viewer.

Requirements

The group must provide:

MSC would like to be able to use a wider range of tools and methods to interrogate the digitised newspapers in order to enable:

- Analysis of themes e.g. trends of student experience over time, such as:
 - The prevalence of misogyny, racism, etc.
 - Shifts in political outlook (to the right or the left)
 - Subjects under discussion in general for students
- Identification of sensitive content for review, such as:
 - Slander
 - High profile names
 - Distressing content

Ideally these enhanced methods of interrogating the scans would also be accessible for researchers to use on the locked down terminal in the reading room.

The task could also involve (or this could be offered as a separate project) the checking and correcting of the OCR'd text and the inclusion of a means of describing images used within the newspaper articles for both improved searching and accessibility purposes.

Skills

Highly desirable:

Experience in or interest in using machine learning in interpreting printed materials

Desirable:

Interest in archives
Interest in digital humanities
Interest in ethics of digital representation of marginalised communities.

Submission / Award information

Date of Submission:

September 2026

Date of Pitch:

October 2026

Notification of award:

October 2026

For further information on this proposal, the team representative should in the first instance e-mail the lead contact stated above at the e-mail address provided.